

How Eleven Real Film Courses Compare to This Plan

Eleven publicly posted university syllabi with complete screening lists — 194 total screenings, 147 distinct films — set against the 80-film sabbatical plan.

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The eleven courses

Course	Institution	Films	Type	Textbook
21L.011 The Film Experience	MIT (Thorburn)	22	Chronological + genre	Cook, <i>A History of Narrative Film</i>
21L.706 Studies in Film	MIT (Kibel)	11	Film paired with literature	— (literary texts)
FILM 2110 History to 1952	Utah (McEnteggart)	15	Strict chronology by movement	Cook

Course	Institution	Films	Type	Textbook
MCS 207 History of Cinema I	DePaul (Jones)	10	Chronology + race/avant-garde	— (PDF readings)
MRTS 3475 Film History from 1945	UNT (Sutton)	11	Chronological by region	Thompson & Bordwell, <i>Film History</i>
FST 200 Intro to Film Study	UNC Wilmington (Berliner)	23	Formal concepts	Bordwell & Thompson, <i>Film Art</i>
ENG 2300 Film Analysis	Florida (Robinson)	15	Formal concepts + theory	<i>Film Art</i> + Corrigan
INI 115Y Intro to Film Study	Toronto (Keil)	39	Formal concepts, full year	<i>Film Art</i>
FI 224G International Cinema	Eckerd (Kunze)	13	One film per national movement	Nowell-Smith, <i>Oxford History</i>
COM 210 World Cinema	UC Davis (Lu)	26	Theory + national case studies	— (course reader)
WCL 2352 Intro to World Cinema	Houston (Kleinheider)	9	Thematic ("Crossing Borders")	Corrigan

Also worth a look, though I didn't score them: [Hunter College FILM 21200](#), a deliberately revisionist post-1945 survey with a full public course site, and the [Harvard Film & Visual Studies PhD viewing list](#), which is a canon rather than a course.

Three species of course

The eleven sort cleanly into three types, and they are not doing the same thing at all.

1. The chronological history survey (Utah, DePaul, UNT, MIT 21L.011). Marches through periods in order, one film per movement, tethered to a textbook — Cook or Thompson & Bordwell. Usually split into two semesters at 1945. The film is an *example of a period*; you watch one Neorealist film, not three.

2. The formal-concepts analysis course (UNC Wilmington, Florida, Toronto). Organized by technique — mise-en-scène, then cinematography, then editing, then sound — with films chosen to demonstrate the technique regardless of era. Almost universally assigns Bordwell & Thompson's *Film Art*. Jumps freely from 1924 to 2001 in a single week.

3. The world-cinema survey (Eckerd, UC Davis, Houston). One film per national tradition, explicitly framed against Hollywood as the default. Eckerd's course contains *zero* US films, by design.

The sabbatical plan is a fourth thing. It's closest to type 3 in content and type 2 in Unit 1, but its organizing bet — 3–4 films inside one director or movement so that style becomes legible through

repetition — is something **none of these eleven courses does**. They can't: a 15-week term with one screening slot can't spend four weeks on Bergman. That constraint is exactly what a sabbatical removes.

Scale

	Films
Median academic course	15
Largest (Toronto, full year)	39
The plan	80 core / ~123 with extensions

The plan is roughly **five courses' worth of screenings** — closer to an undergraduate concentration than to any single class. Worth knowing, mostly as reassurance that the pacing isn't casual.

Where the canons agree

Films appearing in **3 or more** of the eleven syllabi — the hard consensus core:

Film	Syllabi	In the plan?
The General (1926)	4	✓ Week 8
Singin' in the Rain (1952)	4	✓ Week 7
Citizen Kane (1941)	4	✓ Week 1
Meshes of the Afternoon (1943)	4	x
His Girl Friday (1940)	3	✓ Week 4
Bicycle Thieves (1948)	3	✓ Week 11
Rashomon (1950)	3	✓ Week 3
The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari (1920)	3	x
Battleship Potemkin (1925)	3	✓ Week 10
The Celebration (1998)	3	x
North by Northwest (1959)	3	x
Metropolis (1927)	3	x (listed as an extension)
Tokyo Story (1953)	3	✓ Week 17

The plan has 8 of the 13. That's a good hit rate on the true canon.

Where they diverge — the honest finding

Only 35 of the plan's 80 films appear in *any* of the eleven syllabi. 45 appear in none.

That sounds damning and mostly isn't. It's an artifact of the depth strategy: these courses screen one Kurosawa, and the plan screens four. *Seven Samurai* shows up in the syllabi; *Ugetsu*, *Harakiri*, *High and Low*, and *Woman in the Dunes* don't. Same for Bergman (they screen *Persona*; the plan adds three more), Wong Kar-wai, Antonioni, Fellini, Tarkovsky, and all of New Hollywood.

So the divergence is largely *deliberate and defensible*. But three gaps are not.

Gap 1 — Avant-garde and experimental film: 15 titles across the syllabi, zero in the plan

This is the biggest real omission. Nearly every formal-analysis course devotes a full unit to it: *Meshes of the Afternoon* (4 syllabi), *Un Chien Andalou*, *Ballet mécanique*, *Mothlight*, *Kustom Kar Kommandos*, *Scorpio Rising*, *A Movie*, *La Jetée*. These are taught because they isolate what narrative films do invisibly — and most are **under 30 minutes**, so the cost of adding them is trivial.

Gap 2 — Documentary: 9 titles across the syllabi, zero in the plan

Night and Fog (32 min), *Land Without Bread*, *Triumph of the Will*, *The Hour of the Furnaces*, *Dark Days*. The plan treats “film” as “narrative feature” throughout, which is a real narrowing.

Gap 3 — Early cinema and German Expressionism

The plan starts in 1924 with Keaton. The syllabi spend **19% of screenings pre-1930** against the plan's 8%, and they all begin with Lumière/Méliès/Porter shorts — *The Great Train Robbery*, *A Trip to the Moon*. More pointedly, **German Expressionism is missing entirely from the plan's core**: *Caligari* is in 3 syllabi, *Metropolis* in 3, *Nosferatu* and *The Last Laugh* in one each. The plan has Murnau's *Sunrise*, which is a Hollywood film.

Taken together, non-narrative and pre-1915 material is **24% of everything the eleven courses screen** and **0% of the plan**.

Chronological weight, side by side

Period	The plan	The 11 syllabi
pre-1930	8%	19%
1930–45	6%	16%
1946–59	22%	21%
1960–79	41%	18%
1980–94	10%	9%
1995+	12%	17%

The plan is bulged hard at 1960–79 — New Hollywood, the New Waves, Tarkovsky, the Japanese peak. That's a defensible taste (it's arguably the richest twenty years in the medium), but it's twice the academic weighting, and it's paid for out of the 1920s–40s.

Where the plan is *ahead* of the academic courses

Worth saying: on **Asian cinema the plan is substantially deeper than any of the eleven**. Yang's *A Brighter Summer Day* and *Yi Yi*, Kobayashi's *Harakiri*, Wong's *Days of Being Wild*, Hou — none appear in any syllabus here. Same for the Iranian and Senegalese units beyond the two obligatory titles. Several of these courses handle “world cinema” with a single film per continent.

What I'd actually change

Five suggestions, roughly in order of payoff. All are cheap — mostly short films slotted into existing weeks.

1. **Add *Meshes of the Afternoon* (14 min) and *Un Chien Andalou* (16 min) to Week 10**, alongside *Man with a Movie Camera*. That week is already about non-narrative form; it becomes an avant-garde unit for 30 extra minutes.
2. **Add *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* (1920) to Week 9**, replacing or joining *The Passion of Joan of Arc*. This fixes the German Expressionism hole, and Expressionist lighting is the thing Unit 2's noir week is descended from — it makes Week 6 land harder.
3. **Add *Night and Fog* (32 min) to Week 36**, next to *Come and See*. Documentary enters the plan in the one unit where it belongs thematically, and it's the most-taught documentary in the sample.
4. **Add *La Jetée* (28 min) to Week 40**, with *2001* and *Playtime*. It's in 2 syllabi, it's 28 minutes, and a photo-roman about time and memory sitting beside Kubrick is a genuinely good pairing.
5. **Consider swapping in *North by Northwest* for *Rear Window* in Week 1**, or adding it. Hitchcock appears across these syllabi more than any other director, and *North by Northwest* is the one they teach for formal analysis — the crop-duster sequence is the standard editing example.

Items 1–4 add about **90 minutes of total runtime** across the year and close the two structural gaps. That's the whole fix.

Sources: the eleven syllabi linked in the table above. Overlap figures computed by title-normalized intersection across 194 screenings, 17 August 2026.